

TOOLSHARE

University Equipment Borrowing System

USER GUIDE

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1. Introduction to ToolShare

ToolShare is a web-based equipment management platform designed for universities and educational institutions. It enables students and staff to discover, book, and manage shared laboratory and departmental equipment in a streamlined, fully tracked workflow.

1.1 What is ToolShare?

ToolShare replaces manual spreadsheets and paper-based sign-out sheets with a centralized digital system. Key capabilities include:

- Real-time equipment availability browsing with date-range filtering
- Online borrow requests with reason/justification capture
- Staff-controlled approval and rejection workflow
- Physical checkout with before-condition photo documentation
- Return processing with after-condition photo comparison
- Automated reminders and overdue tracking
- In-app and email notifications at every stage
- Analytics dashboard for usage reporting

1.2 Who Is This Guide For?

This guide covers three user roles:

Role	Typical User	Primary Actions
Student	Undergraduate, graduate, or other borrowers	Browse, request, track bookings
Faculty/Staff	Lab Instructors, Instructors, equipment owners	Approve requests, checkout, returns
Admin	System administrators, IT, department coordinators	Full system control: users, categories, settings

How to Use This Guide

Jump to the section for your role. Each section is self-contained with step-by-step instructions. Callout boxes like this one highlight tips, warnings, and important notes.

2. Getting Started

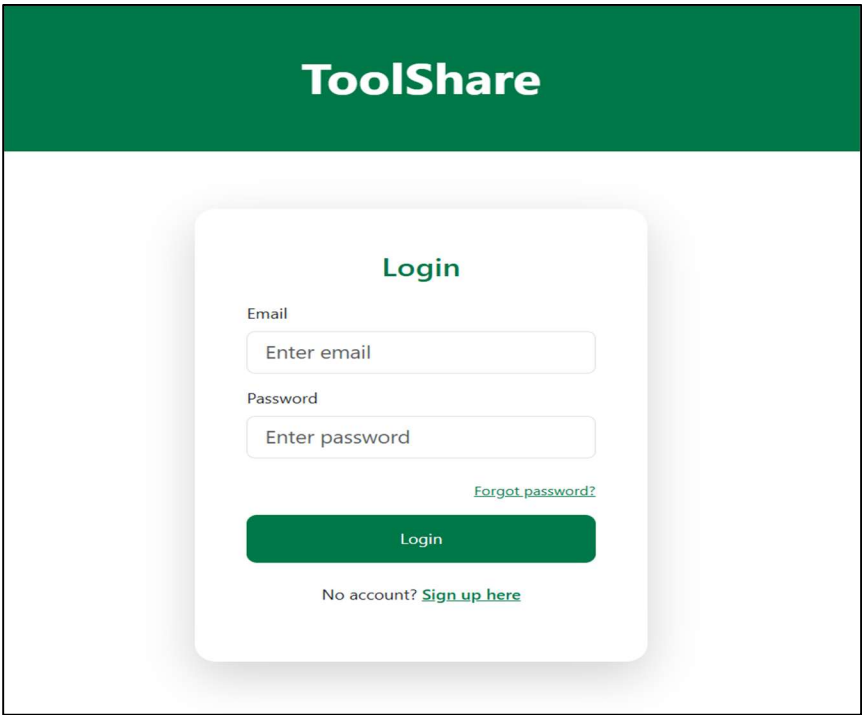
2.1 System Requirements

ToolShare is a web-based application — no installation required. You only need:

- A modern web browser: Google Chrome, Mozilla Firefox, Microsoft Edge, or Safari
- A stable internet connection
- Your university-issued email address and password

2.2 Accessing ToolShare

1. Open your web browser.
2. Navigate to the ToolShare URL provided by your institution (e.g., toolshare.university.edu).
3. You will see the Login page.



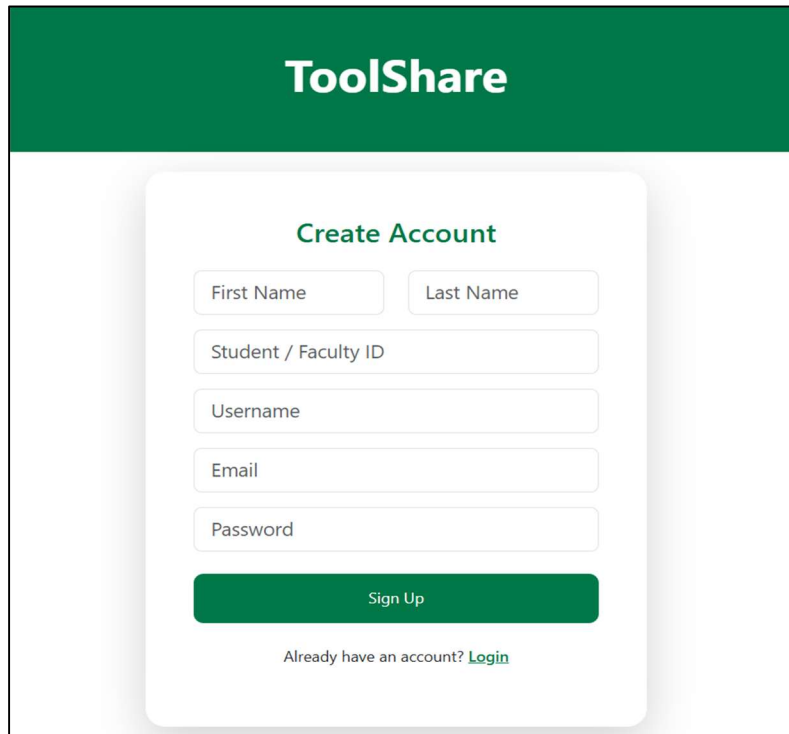
1.Login page

2.3 Registering a New Account

If your institution requires self-registration (check with your administrator first):

1	Open Login Page	Navigate to the ToolShare URL in your browser.
2	Click Register	Find and click the Register or Sign-Up link on the login page.

3	Complete the Form	Enter your full name, university email address, and a strong password.
4	Submit	Click the Register / Create Account button.
5	You Are Logged In	You will be redirected to the ToolShare home page automatically.



2.SignUp Page

2.4 Logging In

1	Go to Login Page	Navigate to the ToolShare URL.
2	Enter Email	Type your university email address in the Email field.
3	Enter Password	Type your password in the Password field.
4	Click Sign In	Click the Sign In / Login button.
5	Home Screen	You are now logged in and will see your personalized dashboard.

3. Navigating ToolShare

3.1 The Navigation Menu

After logging in, you will see the main navigation bar at the top (or side) of the screen. The menu items available depend on your user role.

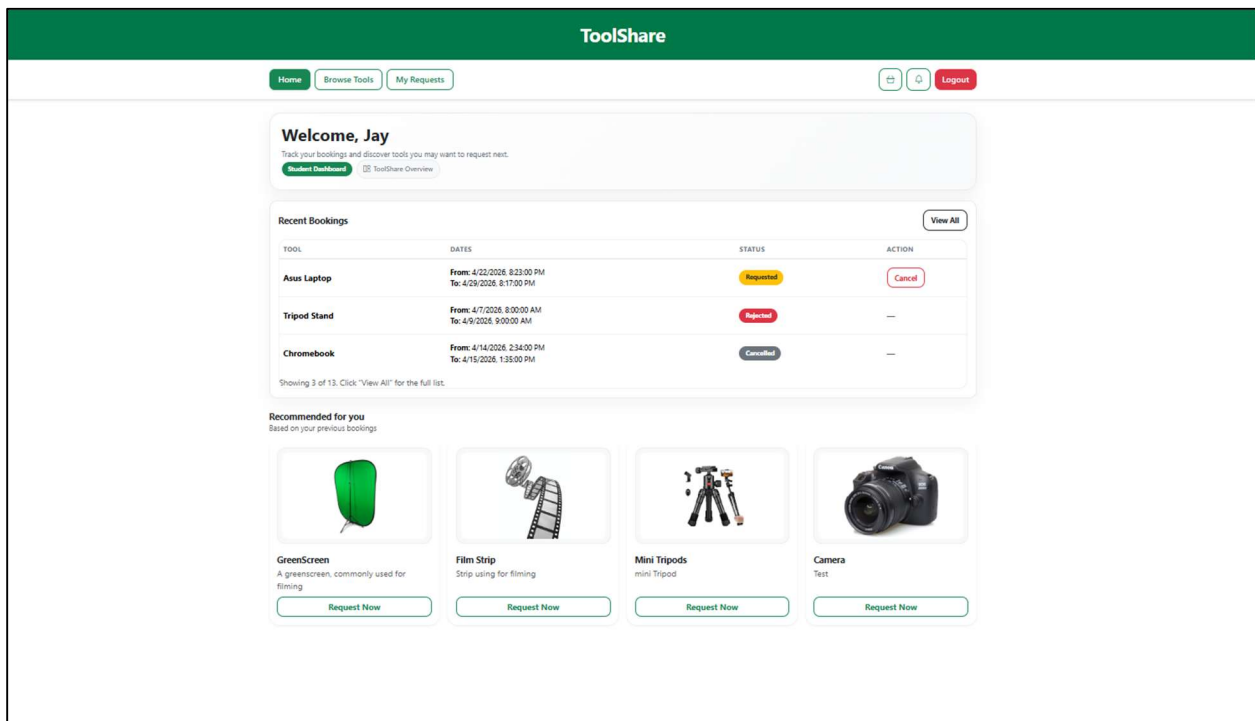


3.Student Page Navbar

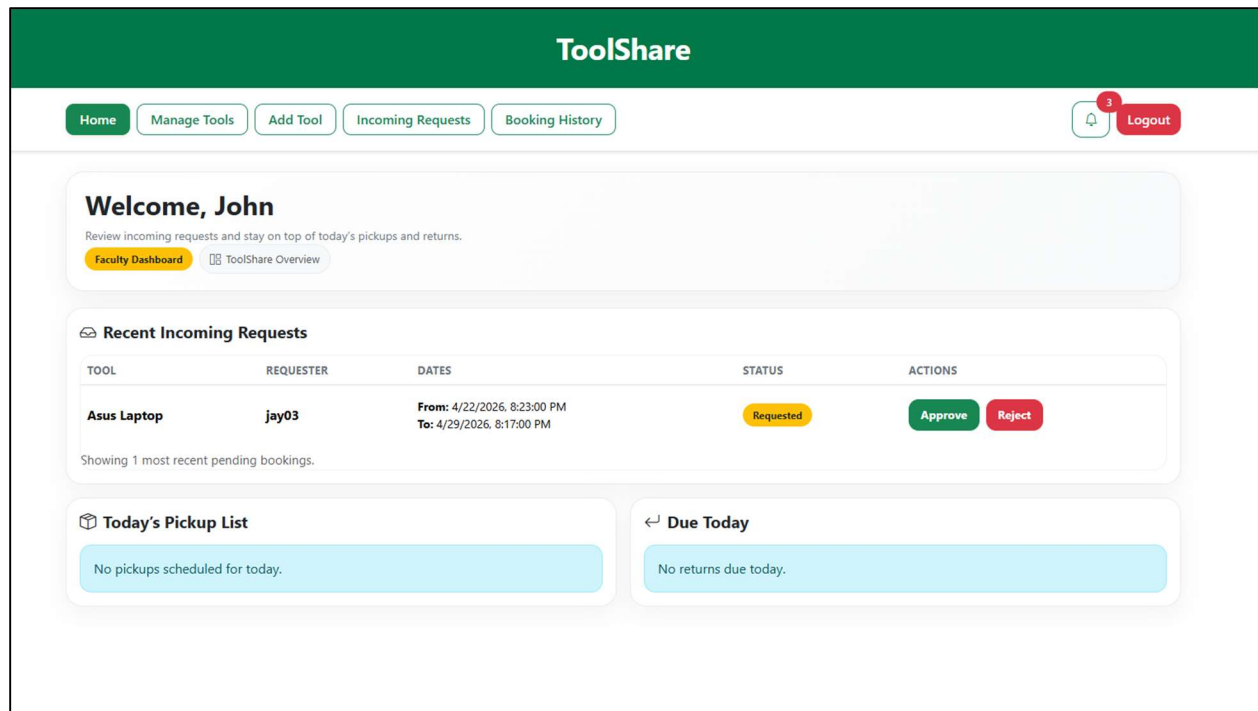
3.2 Dashboard Overview

The dashboard is your home base in ToolShare. It provides a quick summary of:

- Your active bookings and their status
- Pending requests awaiting staff approval (Students)
- Incoming requests requiring your review (Faculty/Staff)
- Recent notifications
- Quick access buttons for common actions



4.Student Dashboard



5.Faculty Dashboard

3.3 Notification Bell

The notification bell icon in the navigation bar shows a badge when you have unread notifications. Click it to open the notifications panel, which displays:

- Booking status updates (Approved, Rejected, CheckedOut, Returned)
- Automated reminders when your booking end date is approaching
- Overdue alerts if equipment has not been returned on time

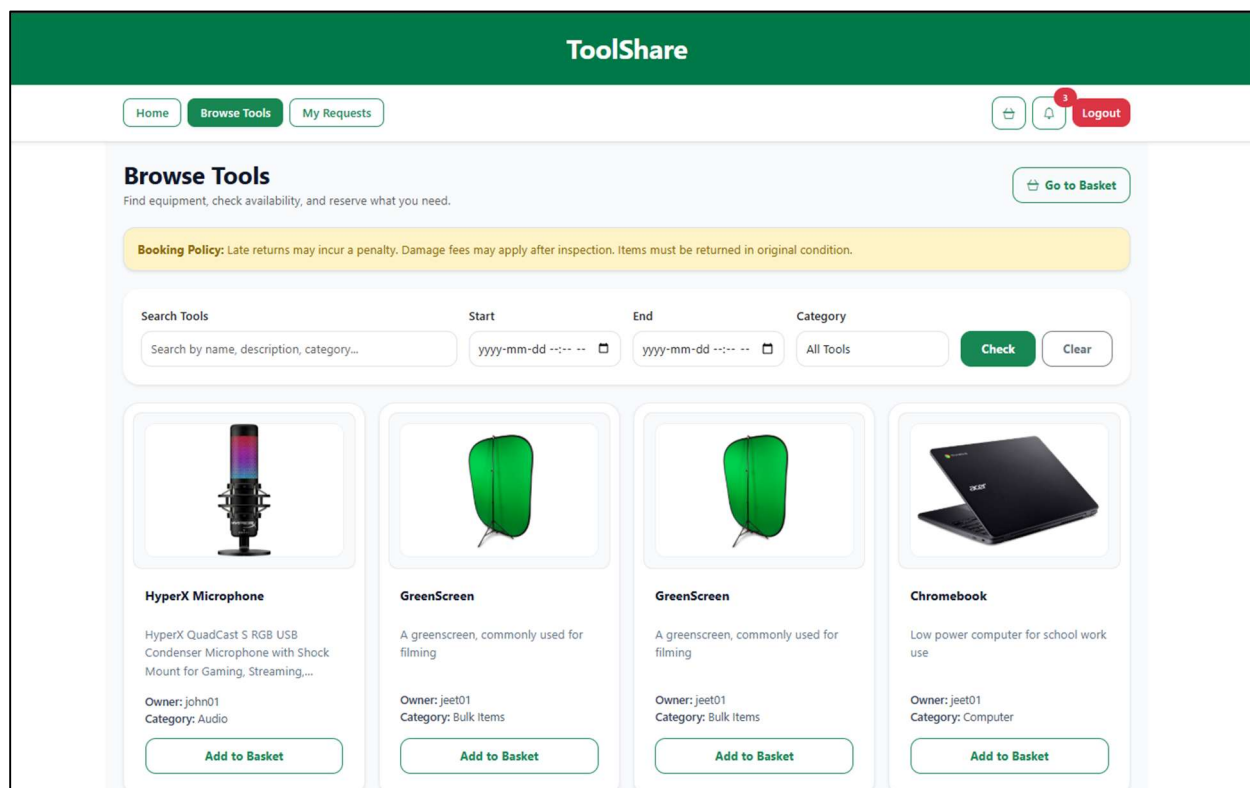
4. Student Guide

This section covers everything a student (borrower) needs to use ToolShare — from discovering available equipment to tracking your booking through return.

4.1 Browsing Equipment

The Browse Equipment page displays all items available in the ToolShare catalog.

1	Open Browse	Click Browse Tools in the navigation menu.
2	View the Catalog	A list of all equipment items is displayed with name, category, and availability indicator.
3	Search / Filter	Use the search bar to find items by keyword or use the filter panel to narrow by category or date range
4	View Item Details	Click on any item card to open the item detail page with full description, specifications, and photos.



6. Browse Tools

4.2 Filtering by Availability Date

Use the date filter to see only items available during your desired borrow period — this prevents you from requesting equipment that is already booked.

1	Open Browse Equipment	Navigate to the Browse page.
2	Select Start Date	Click the Start Date field and pick the date you need the equipment.
3	Select End Date	Click the End Date field and pick your return date.
4	Apply Filter	Click Search or Apply — items that are unavailable during your selected range will be hidden.
5	Review Results	Only equipment available for your full requested period is shown.

4.3 Submitting a Borrow Request

Once you have found the equipment you need, submit a borrow request. Note that submitting a request does not guarantee approval — a staff member must review and approve it.

1	Open Item Details	Click on the equipment item to open its detail page.
2	Click Book / Request	Click the Book This Item or Request button.
3	Select Dates	Choose your desired Start Date (pickup date) and End Date (return date).
4	Enter Reason	Briefly describe why you need the equipment (e.g., course name, project, lab assignment).
5	Submit Request	Click Submit Request or Confirm. Your request is now in Pending status.
6	Confirmation	You will see a success message and receive an in-app notification confirming submission.

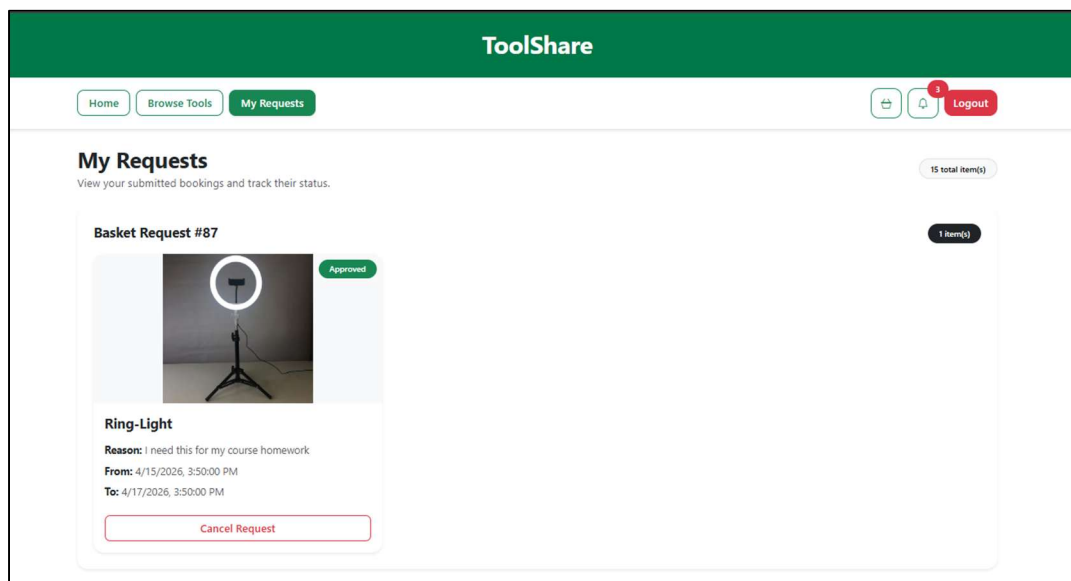
☒ After Submitting

Your request status is now Pending. A staff member responsible for that item will be notified. You will receive an email and/or in-app notification when your request is Approved or Rejected. You can monitor the status in My Bookings at any time.

4.4 Tracking Your Bookings (My Bookings)

The My Bookings page is your personal booking history and status tracker.

1	Open My Bookings	Click My Bookings in the navigation menu.
2	View All Requests	A table or list of all your requests is displayed, sorted by most recent.
3	Check Status	Each request shows its status (see Status Guide below).
4	View Details	Click on a request row to see full details including dates, item info, and any rejection reason if applicable.



7. My Requests Page

4.5 Understanding Booking Statuses

Each borrow request moves through a defined lifecycle. The status badge on your booking tells you exactly where things stand:

Pending	Request has been submitted; awaiting staff review.
Approved	Request approved by staff; awaiting physical checkout.
Rejected	Request was declined by staff (reason provided).
CheckedOut	Equipment physically issued; in use by borrower.
Returned	Equipment returned and booking closed.

Overdue

Equipment not returned by the agreed end date.

⚠ What to Do If Your Request is Rejected

Open the rejected request in My Bookings to read the rejection reason provided by staff.

Address the issue (e.g., adjust your dates, clarify your purpose) and submit a new request if appropriate.

If you believe the rejection was made in error, contact the equipment owner or department directly.

4.6 Picking Up Equipment (After Approval)

Once your request is Approved, you need to physically pick up the equipment from the staff member or lab. The staff member will complete the checkout process in the system at the time of pickup.

- Bring your student ID or any identification required by your department.
- Inspect the equipment condition together with the staff member at pickup.
- Staff will photograph the equipment (before condition images) and mark it as CheckedOut in the system.
- You will receive a notification confirming the checkout.

i You Cannot Checkout Yourself

The Checkout action can only be performed by Faculty/Staff in the system. You will receive an automated notification when checkout is completed.

4.7 Returning Equipment

Return equipment by the agreed End Date to avoid overdue status. The staff member will process the return in the system when you hand the equipment back.

- Return the item to the designated location or staff member before or on your End Date.
- Staff will inspect the equipment, photograph it (after condition images), and process the return.
- You will receive a notification confirming the return and closure of your booking.

🔔 Overdue Bookings

If you do not return equipment by the End Date, the system will automatically mark your booking as Overdue.

You and the responsible staff member will both receive overdue notifications.

Return the equipment as soon as possible and notify the staff member directly.

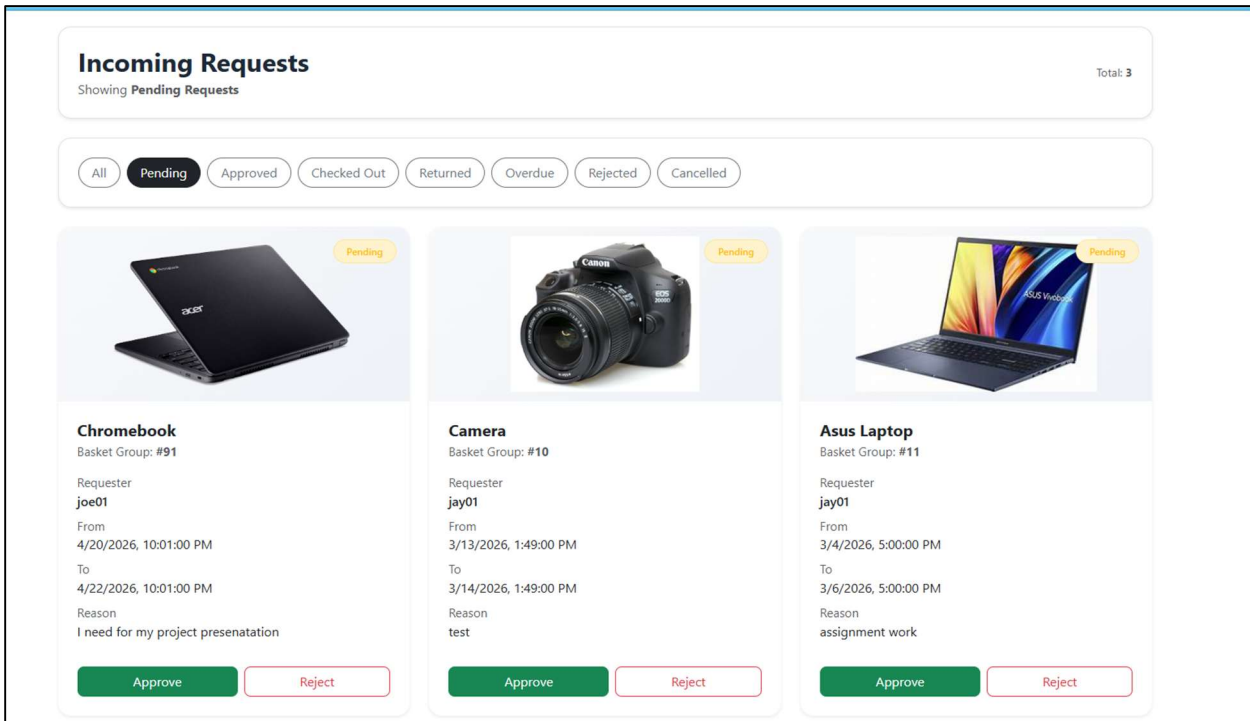
5. Faculty / Staff Guide

Faculty members, lab managers, and other staff are responsible for managing equipment and processing the full booking lifecycle — from reviewing requests to issuing and receiving equipment.

5.1 Viewing Incoming Requests

When a student submits a request for equipment you manage, you will receive an in-app and email notification. You can also access all pending requests at any time.

1	Open Requests	Click Incoming Requests or Manage Requests in the navigation menu.
2	View Request List	All requests for your items are listed with requester name, item, dates, reason, and status.
3	Review Request	Click a request row to open the full details before acting.



8.Incoming Request Page

5.2 Approving a Request

1	Open the Request	Click on the request you want to approve.
2	Review Details	Confirm the dates, requester identity, and stated reason are acceptable.
3	Click Approve	Click the Approve button.
4	Confirmation	The request status changes to Approved. The student is automatically notified by email and in-app notification.

5.3 Rejecting a Request

1	Open the Request	Click on the request you want to reject.
2	Click Reject	Click the Reject button.
3	Enter Reason (Recommended)	Type a brief reason for rejection in the Rejection Reason field. This helps the student understand and reapply correctly.
4	Confirm Rejection	Click Confirm Reject.
5	Notification Sent	The student is automatically notified with the rejection reason included.

Best Practice for Rejections

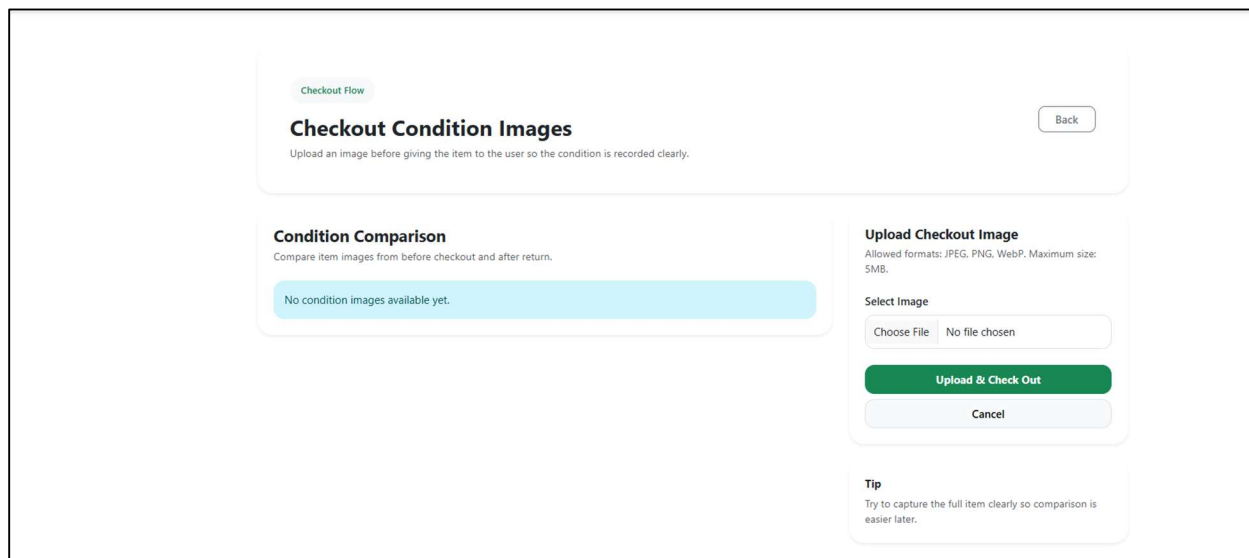
Always include a rejection reason. Students rely on this feedback to correct issues and resubmit. Common reasons: date conflict, missing prerequisite training, item under maintenance, insufficient justification.

5.4 Processing Checkout (Issuing Equipment)

Checkout is the physical handover of equipment to the borrower. This step is performed by you now the student picks up the item.

1	Locate the Booking	Open the approved booking from Incoming Requests or your dashboard.
2	Inspect Equipment	Physically inspect the item with the student and note any pre-existing condition issues.
3	Click Checkout	Click the Checkout button on the booking detail page.

4	Upload BEFORE Images	Upload one or more clear photos of the equipment in its current condition. These are the 'before' condition images. This is critical for documenting equipment state at the time of issue.
5	Confirm Checkout	Click Confirm Checkout or Submit.
6	Status Updated	The booking status changes to CheckedOut. The student receives a notification.



9. Checkout Page

Before Condition Images

Always upload clear, well-lit photos from multiple angles.

These images are stored permanently and used to compare against return condition.

Skipping or submitting poor quality images leaves your department without documentation in case of disputes.

5.5 Processing a Return

When the student returns the equipment, process the return to close the booking and document the equipment condition at return.

1	Locate the Booking	Find the CheckedOut booking from your dashboard or Incoming Requests.
2	Inspect Returned Equipment	Physically inspect the equipment with the student upon return.

3	Click Return	Click the Return button on the booking detail page.
4	Upload AFTER Images	Upload photos of the equipment in its returned condition. Compare mentally to the Before images.
5	Add Notes (If needed)	If you notice any damage or issues compared to checkout condition, document it in the Notes field.
6	Confirm Return	Click Confirm Return.
7	Booking Closed	Status changes to Returned. The student receives a confirmation notification.

Return Condition Images

Upload an image after receiving the item back. You can also add a note for damage, missing parts, or anything important.

Condition Comparison
Compare item images from before checkout and after return.

Before Checkout 1

After Return 0
No return images uploaded yet.

Upload Return Image
Allowed formats: JPEG, PNG, WebP. Maximum size: 5MB.

Select Image
Choose File No file chosen

Return Note / Damage Note
Example: Small scratch on the side, charger missing, item returned in good condition, etc.

Add any note about damage, missing parts, or item condition.

Upload & Return
Cancel

10.Return Page

5.6 Managing Equipment Items

As a staff member, you can add, edit, and manage equipment items assigned to your department or lab.

Adding New Equipment

1	Open Equipment Management	Navigate to Manage Tools in the menu.
2	Click Add Item	Click the Add New Item.

3	Fill in Details	Enter: Item Name, Description, Category, Quantity available, and any special instructions.
4	Upload Photos	Upload one or more photos of the equipment for the catalog.
5	Save	Click Save or Create Item. The item is now visible in the Browse Equipment catalog.

Add New Item

Add one or multiple tools with a cleaner and easier form.

Item Name *

Enter item name

Description *

Write a short description

Quantity *

1

You can clear this with backspace and type a new value.

Category *

Select a category

☐ This item does not have a serial number

Serial Number *

Serial Number 1

Enter serial number 1

Max 15 characters

Upload Image *

Choose File

No file chosen

Add Item

Cancel

11.Add Item Page

Editing or Deactivating Equipment

- To edit an item, open it from Manage Equipment and click Edit.
- To temporarily remove an item from the catalog (e.g., for maintenance), mark it as Inactive or Unavailable.
- Items cannot be permanently deleted if they have active or historical bookings. Contact Admin to archive.

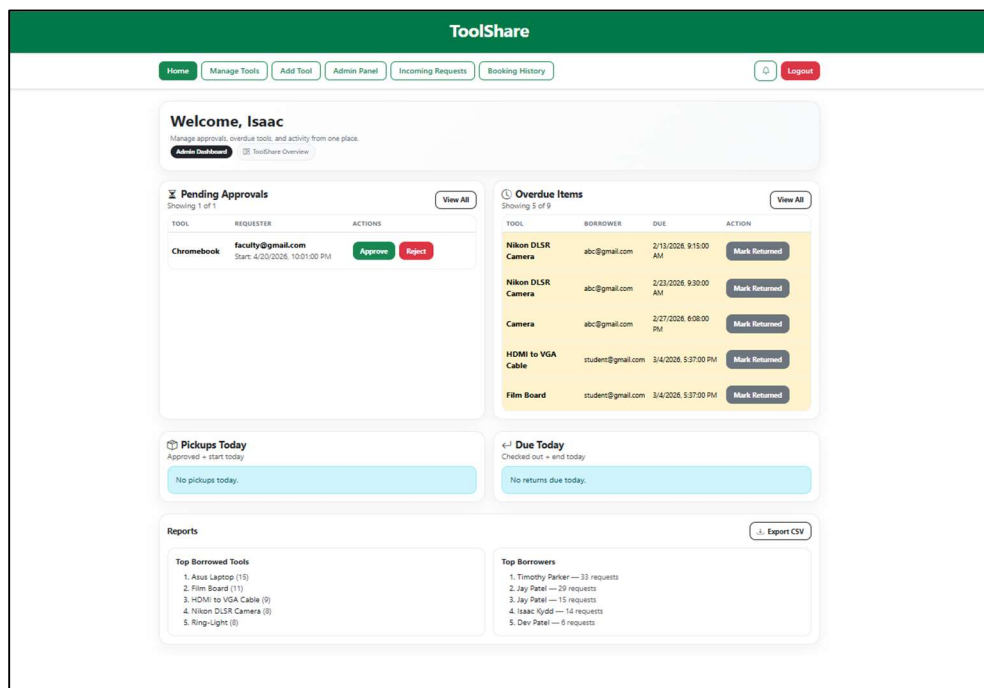
6. Administrator Guide

Administrators have full system control. In addition to all Faculty/Staff capabilities, admins can manage users, categories, and system settings.

6.1 Admin Dashboard

The admin dashboard provides a system-wide overview, including:

- Total active bookings across all departments
- Pending requests awaiting any staff action
- Overdue bookings requiring follow-up
- User account summaries
- Quick links to all management sections



12.Admin Dashboard

6.2 Managing Users

1	Open User Management	Navigate to Admin > Manage Users.
2	View User List	All registered users are listed with their name, email, role, and account status.
3	Edit a User	Click on a user row and click Edit to modify their name, email, or role assignment.

4	Change Role	Use the Role dropdown to change a user between Student, Faculty/Staff, and Admin.
5	Activate/Deactivate	Toggle the Active status to enable or disable a user account without deleting it.
6	Save Changes	Click Save to apply the changes.

Role Assignment Warning

Assigning a user the admin role grants full system control including user management. Assigning Faculty/Staff role allows approval, checkout, and return capabilities. Always verify the identity of users before elevating their permissions.

6.3 Managing Categories

Equipment categories help users filter and find items in the catalog. Admins can create, edit, and reorder categories.

1	Open Categories	Navigate to Admin > Manage Categories.
2	Add Category	Click Add Category, enter the category name, and optionally add an icon or color.
3	Edit Category	Click Edit on any existing category to rename or update it.
4	Delete	Delete a category only if it has no items assigned. To remove a populated category, reassign all items first.

6.4 Viewing Audit Logs

The audit log records every significant action taken in the system for accountability and compliance purposes.

- Accessible from Admin > Audit Logs.
- Every approval, rejection, checkout, return, and user change is logged with: timestamp, user who performed the action, affected booking/item, and action details.
- Logs can be filtered by date range, user, action type, or item.
- Logs cannot be edited or deleted to ensure integrity.

7. Roles & Permissions Reference

The following table summarizes what each role can do across all ToolShare features.

Feature	Student	Faculty/Staff	Admin
Browse equipment	✓	✓	✓
Filter by availability	✓	✓	✓
Submit borrow request	✓	✓	✓
View own bookings	✓	✓	✓
Approve/Reject requests	—	✓	✓
Checkout equipment	—	✓	✓
Process returns	—	✓	✓
Add/Edit equipment items	—	✓	✓
View analytics dashboard	—	✓	✓
Manage all users	—	—	✓
Manage categories	—	—	✓
View audit logs	—	—	✓

8. Notifications & Alerts

8.1 How Notifications Work

ToolShare sends notifications through two channels simultaneously:

- In-app notifications: Appear as a badge on the bell icon in the navigation bar. Click the bell to read them.
- Email notifications: Sent to your university email address on file. Check your inbox and junk/spam folder if you don't see expected emails.

8.2 Notification Reference

Event	Recipient	Message Sent
Student submits request	Faculty/Staff	<i>New borrow request submitted for [Item Name]</i>
Request Approved	Student	<i>Your request for [Item] has been approved</i>
Request Rejected	Student	<i>Your request for [Item] was rejected: [Reason]</i>
Checkout Completed	Student	<i>Equipment [Item] has been checked out to you</i>
Return Processed	Student	<i>Your return of [Item] has been confirmed</i>
Booking end date approaching	Student + Staff	<i>Reminder: [Item] is due for return on [Date]</i>
Booking marked Overdue	Student + Staff	<i>OVERDUE: [Item] was not returned by [Date]</i>

8.3 Automated Reminders & Overdue System

The ToolShare scheduler runs automated jobs to keep all parties informed:

- Reminder notifications are sent a configurable number of days before the booking end date (typically 1-2 days prior). Contact your administrator for the exact reminder schedule.
- If equipment is not returned by the end date, the system automatically marks the booking as Overdue and sends alerts to both the student and responsible staff member.
- Overdue alerts repeat on a schedule until the return is processed.

9. Troubleshooting

Issue	Likely Cause	Solution
Cannot log in	Wrong email or password; account not yet activated	Check email format (must be university email). Reset password via Forgot Password link. Contact admin if account is not yet active.
Item shows as unavailable	Item is already booked during your selected dates	Try different dates using the availability date filter. Contact the equipment owner to check for upcoming availability.
Request stuck in Pending	Staff has not yet reviewed your request	Wait for staff review (typically 1-2 business days). If urgent, contact the equipment owner directly.
Did not receive email notification	Email in spam/junk folder; email provider delay	Check your spam/junk folder. Add the ToolShare email address to your safe senders list. Check in-app notifications as backup.
Cannot upload condition images	File too large; unsupported format	Use JPG or PNG format. Reduce file size to under 5MB. Try a different browser if the upload button is unresponsive.
My booking shows Overdue incorrectly	Return was processed but not reflected	Contact staff to confirm they processed the return in the system. Overdue status clears automatically once return is recorded.
Cannot see the Approve button	You are not assigned as owner of that item	Confirm your role is Faculty/Staff. Verify the item is assigned to your department. Contact your admin to correct ownership.
Analytics page is blank or loading	Date range too large; data still loading	Try a shorter date range. Refresh the page. Contact admin if the issue persists.
Browser showing old data	Browser cache issue	Hard refresh the page (Ctrl+Shift+R or Cmd+Shift+R). Clear browser cache. Try an incognito/private window.

Still Need Help?

Contact your department's system administrator or IT helpdesk.

When contacting support, include: your username/email, the booking ID or item name, and a description of what you were trying to do when the issue occurred.